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Bob Knowlton (IV)

Maximilian B. Torres

He immediately accepted the position and notified Jerrold by letter, which he mailed on a Friday night to Jerrold's home. The letter was quite brief and Jerrold was stunned. Knowlton merely wrote that he had found a better position; that there were personal reasons why he preferred not to appear at the lab any more; that he would be glad to stop by at a later date from his new place of work, some 40 miles away, to assist if there was any mixup at all in the past work; that he felt sure that Fester could, however, supply any leadership that was required for the group; and that his decision to leave so suddenly was based on some personal circumstances—he hinted at health problems in his family, his mother and father. All of this was fictitious, of course. Jerrold took it at face value but still felt that this was very strange behavior and quite unaccountable since he had always felt his relationship with Knowlton was warm and that Knowlton was satisfied and, as a matter of fact, quite happy and productive.

Jerrold was considerably disturbed because he had already decided to place Fester in charge of another project that was going to be initiated very soon and had been wondering how to explain this to Knowlton, in view of the obvious help and assistance and value Knowlton was getting from Fester and the high regard in which he held him. He had, as a matter of fact, considered the possibility that Knowlton could add to his staff another person with the kind of background and training that had proved so valuable in Fester.

Jerrold made no attempt to meet Knowlton. In a way, he felt aggrieved about the whole thing. Fester, too, was surprised at the suddenness of Knowlton's departure and when Jerrold, in talking to him, asked him whether he had reasons to prefer to stay with the photon group instead of the project for the Air Force which was being organized, he chose the Air Force project and went on to that job the following week. The photon lab was hard hit. The leadership of the lab was given to Link with the understanding that this would be temporary until someone could come in to take over.

This is a revised version of the case adapted by Professor Maximilian B. Torres from the original "Bob Knowlton" case (HBS–Boston, Mass.: Harvard Business School Publishing, by Professors Alex Bavelas, A.H. Rubintein and H.A. Shepard). December 2019.
Cases are designed to promote class discussion rather than to illustrate effective or ineffective management of a given situation.
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